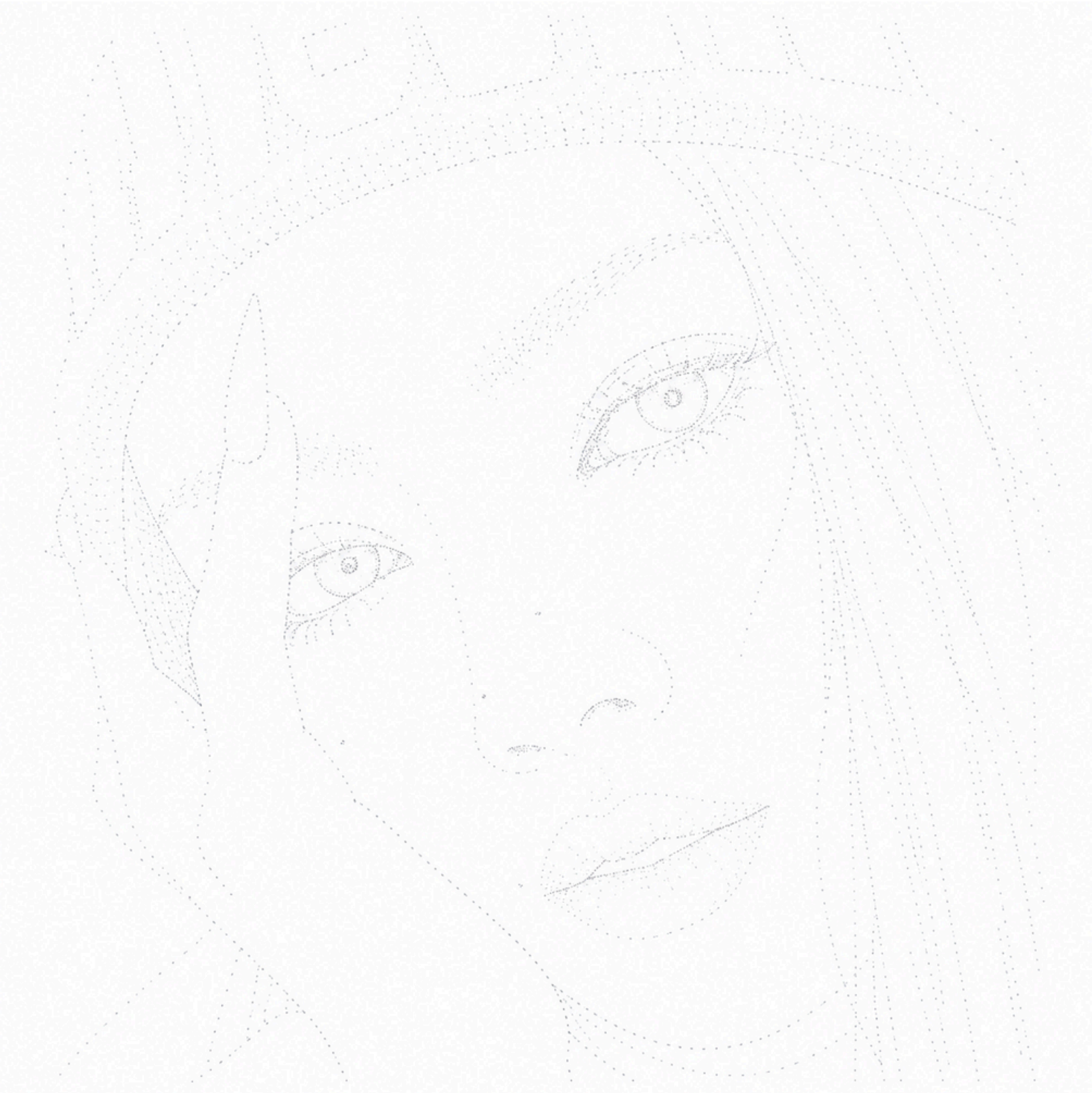
Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



COLORED PENCIL STUDY

Portrait Guide #024

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10–14 hours

Subject A young adult woman with dark hair worn down with loose strands, calm composed expression, warm medium-tan skin, and a grey hat, under diffuse warm light

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

COLOR PALETTE

Cream
PC914
Warm golden undertone for forehead zone and neck; warm light base for warm-key skin; final unifying glaze

Beige Sienna
PC1080
*Light warm red-orange skin highlight and midtone; measured skin base (L*66, C*17, hue 18°); lit plane color*

Clay Rose

PC1017

Warm cream-pink half-tone transition at the turning edge between lit and shadow planes; measured transition hue

Henna

PC1031

Warm red-orange for deeper mid-tone shadow and lower lip edge; saturated transition into core shadow

Blush Pink

PC928

Vascular pink for subsurface scattering (nose, ears, cheeks, lips); mid-face warm zone; thin glowing areas

Ginger Root

PC1084

Warm mid-shadow building; alternative for saturated warm transition if Henna too red

70% French Grey

PC1074

*Measured mid-value warm shadow (L*46, C*17, hue 19°); jaw turning edge; warm undertone in hair and neck shadow*

70% Warm Grey

PC1056

*Measured warm dark shadow (L*41, C*9); jaw core shadow inner edge; warm-dark transition*

90% Warm Grey

PC1058

*Measured deepest warm dark (L*28); jaw underplane; caught reflected light from garment*

90% French Grey

PC1076

*Measured near-black (L*13); deep value anchor for monochromatic map; background dark anchor; hair*

Black

PC935

*Measured darkest dark (L*1); pupils, upper lash line (focal accent), nostril shadows, mouth shadows; re-punch final step*

Silver

PC949

*Measured cool grey (L*68); sclera cool tone; eye accent; cool note in iris*

Violet

PC932

Cool undertone (note within warmth, never plane temperature) in jaw shadow; cool iris ring; cool accent beneath bone

Cloud Blue

PC1023

Optional cool shadow shift in deep mid-face shadow; cool iris accent alternative if Violet too purple

Putty Beige

PC1083

*Measured neutral grey (L*81); hat base; grey hat bounce onto skin below*

20% Warm Grey

PC1051

*Measured light warm grey (L*82); hat lit side; background light side; warm neutral balance*

30% Warm Grey

PC1052

*Measured mid warm grey (L*79); hat mid-tone; background transition; warm grey undertone*

10% Cool Grey

PC1059

*Measured near-white (L*90); peak highlight in step 1 and step 10; brightest lit plane anchor; cool highlight balance*

White

PC938

Burnisher in final step; fuses layers into smooth skin; final peak highlight placement

Olive Green

PC911

Optional complementary veil at warm-to-cool turning edge; warms appearance of adjacent cool by simultaneous contrast

VALUE GROUPING & LIGHT

VALUE GROUPING & LIGHT

Light source direction

Warm diffuse overhead-forward light, soft directional quality; warm key casts gentle shadows on the side planes



- **V1 · HIGHLIGHT**
  L* 80–100 · 45% of the frame
- **V2 · LIGHT**
  L* 60–80 · 24% of the frame
- **V3 · MIDTONE**
  L* 41–60 · 12% of the frame
- **V4 · SHADOW**
  L* 21–41 · 6% of the frame
- **V5 · CORE DARK**
  L* 1–21 · 13% of the frame

Five groups only. Squint at the photo until it looks like this, then build each group as one value before any local colour — if a passage does not change group, it does not change value.

Edge quality notes

Overall soft light means edges are gradual and rounded, except the upper lash line (hardest edge on the face). No hard cast shadows from strong raking light. The turning edge is a wide gradient band, not crisp. The face reads from value and temperature rotation more than from sharp edges.

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Plane Map & Value Structure (Monochromatic Foundation)

Entire face and neck, light pressure throughout

Light pressure, circular strokes, no burnishing; tooth must remain open for nine layers ahead.

Light pressure

- Value carries form, not pigment color. Establish the full value range—highlight, midtone, core shadow, reflected light, cast shadow—in monochromatic pencil before any local color, so the head reads as three-dimensional under one light direction.
- Block the lightest highlight area (cheekbone and eye region where light is keenest) with PC1059 10% Cool Grey at very light pressure, leaving paper tooth open for all layers ahead.
- Establish midtone value across the forehead plane, front cheek, and nose bridge with PC1056 70% Warm Grey at light pressure, as the foundational value bed for all skin colors to follow.
- Lay the core shadow at the terminator (where the face turns away from light), along the jaw shadow and side plane with PC1076 90% French Grey at medium-light pressure—crisp at the turning edge, soft outward.
- Mark the darkest notes (pupils, nostril shadows, mouth corner) with PC935 Black at light-medium pressure as value anchors only, not yet final local color; these will deepen further in step 10.

COLORS PC1059 10% Cool Grey · PC1056 70% Warm Grey · PC1076 90% French Grey · PC935 Black

TRANSITION

Paper white (PC1059 lightest) → PC1056 warm midtone → PC1076 warm shadow, warming outward; the turning edge (terminator) cools slightly relative to the lit plane.

↔ If PC1056 feels too cool, substitute PC1074 70% French Grey (warmer midtone). If PC1076 is not dark enough, substitute PC1058 90% Warm Grey (deeper, still warm).

STOP WHEN

The face shows a full monochromatic range from paper white to near-black, with every plane reading its position in space. · Hand stays relaxed; pencil slides, never drags.

✦ *Do not fill regions; just establish zones and values as a skeleton. This monochromatic map is half the drawing—the rest is glazing color onto it. If the map reads flat, the value range is too narrow or compressed into midtones—spread it: let light hit paper, let shadow reach the reference depth.*

02 Undertone & Three-Zone Temperature Map (Golden, Red-Pink, Cool-Violet)

Forehead zone, mid-face zone, jaw-chin zone, in overlapping bands

Very light pressure, circular strokes, overlapping bands; the violet is a glaze only, not a fill.

Light pressure

- A face under warm light reads warm overall, but its three zones—forehead (golden bone), mid-face (red-pink vascular), jaw-chin (cooler denser tissue)—stay visibly distinct in temperature or the whole head reads like a mask.
- Forehead zone with PC914 Cream at light pressure over the value map, naming the golden-yellow undertone of bone and blood close to surface; this sets the warmest zone.
- Mid-face zone (cheeks, bridge of nose, temples) with PC928 Blush Pink at light pressure, declaring the warmest, most saturated local color; it should sit slightly more saturated than forehead and jaw.
- Jaw and chin cool accent: very light glaze of PC932 Violet at light pressure into the shadow side of jaw and under the chin only—this is a cool NOTE within the warm, never replacing the warmth; it is a thin veil, not a fill.
- Overlap these zones in bands rather than meeting them at hard lines; the zones blend into each other across the cheekbone and jaw line, creating visual continuity.

COLORS PC914 Cream · PC928 Blush Pink · PC932 Violet

TRANSITION

PC914 Cream (forehead warm) → PC928 Blush Pink (cheek saturated warm) → PC932 Violet cool accent (jaw shadow), all at very light pressure so the undertone reads through everything that follows.

↔ If PC928 is too saturated, substitute PC1001 Salmon Pink (lighter, less vivid). If PC932 feels too purple, substitute PC1025 Periwinkle (cooler blue-violet accent, softer).

STOP WHEN

Each zone reads its temperature—forehead golden, cheeks pink-warm, jaw-chin cooler—and the transitions between zones are soft bands, not hard edges. · Hand stays light and relaxed.

✦ *This pass is invisible on its own; it is the invisible skeleton under everything that follows. If zones are not set now, the face will read as one flat temperature—the head will still be pretty, but it will not breathe. The three-zone map is the difference between a painting and a portrait.*

03 Colour Build – Warm Red-Orange Base & Half-Tone Transitions

Frontal planes (forehead, front cheeks), turning edge (cheekbone side, temple side), side planes (jaw side, temple)

Glaze order: lay the transition hue first (PC1017), then deepen the lit plane (PC1080), then deepen the shadow (PC1031 + PC1074). Light to medium pressure; let each pencil dry into the last before the next layer.

Light to Medium pressure

- The most advanced move: the half-tone (the turning edge between light and shadow) is not just darker—it ROTATES in hue and temperature, and this rotation is what the eye reads as roundness. Lay the transition hue first, as a distinct band, before deepening the lit or shadow neighbors.
- Frontal planes (forehead, front cheek facing light) with PC1080 Beige Sienna at light-medium pressure over the value and temperature foundation, building the warm light-plane local color from the measured reference.
- Turning-edge half-tone (cheekbone side, temple side turning away) with PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure, laid ACROSS the turning edge as a thin band BEFORE deepening the shadow beside it—this is the crucial passage; it is warmer than the shadow and cooler than the lit plane, and its presence makes the form read as round.
- Deeper frontal shadow (under the cheekbone, lower cheek turning toward shadow) with PC1031 Henna at medium-light pressure, darkening as it approaches the terminator but staying warm; the transition hue (PC1017) sits between this and the lit plane (PC1080).
- Side planes (temple, side of jaw) with PC1074 70% French Grey at medium pressure, building the darker, warmer shadow note as the face turns away; the transition still keeps some warmth and is never ashy.

COLORS PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1031 Henna · PC1074 70% French Grey

TRANSITION

PC1080 Beige Sienna (lit warm red-orange) → PC1017 Clay Rose (half-tone cream-pink transition, warming/cooling turn) → PC1031 Henna + PC1074 (shadow, darker red-orange and warm grey turn). The edge at the transition cools slightly as the plane turns away from warm key light.

↔ If PC1017 is too pink, substitute PC1085 Peach Beige (more yellow, warmer transition). If PC1031 feels too orange, substitute PC1084 Ginger Root (more neutral, less saturated red).

STOP WHEN

The cheekbone reads round; the turning edge is visibly a different hue from both the lit plane and the shadow. The hue rotation makes the eye understand the form without

a hard boundary. · Hand stays in rhythm; small circular motions, no heavy scrubbing.

✦ *This is where a student drawing turns into an atelier drawing. The half-tone is not a transition in pressure; it is a shift in HUE and TEMPERATURE. If you fade one pencil with pressure instead of laying a distinct middle hue, the face will look muddy and flat. Name the three hues—lit, transition, shadow—before you start, and the roundness will follow.*

04 Eyes (Iris, Pupil, Sclera, Upper Lash Line)

Both eyes: iris, sclera, pupil, upper lash line, lower lash line

Radial strokes in the iris; the upper lash line is one sharp statement, not built up; the lower is glazed soft.

Light to Medium (upper lid medium, iris light, sclera and lower lid very light) pressure

- The upper lash line is the darkest dark on the face and the sharpest, hardest edge; keep it crisp and make it the focal accent. The iris is a radial form with multiple hues, never a flat fill. The sclera is never pure white—it is a cool grey-cream. Pupils are perfectly round, deepest black.
- Upper lid cast shadow from the brow with PC935 Black at medium pressure, a hard edge from the lash line into the lid crease, no softness—this is the focal accent of the face.
- Pupil: PC935 Black, clean filled center, leaving a small white specular highlight (paper or to be lifted and refined in step 10).
- Iris in radial strokes: start with PC1074 70% French Grey warm grey base at light pressure, radiating from pupil outward; overlay PC1080 Beige Sienna warm accent on the lit side (upper-outer) at light pressure, then PC932 Violet cool accent on the shadow side (lower-inner) at light pressure. The iris should show three distinct colors, not one.
- Sclera (white of eye) with PC949 Silver at light pressure, cool grey-tone, never pure white; glaze a very light PC914 Cream on the lit side to warm it slightly and show the light direction.
- Lower lash line and lower lid with PC928 Blush Pink at very light pressure, soft edge, never dark or mirrored to the upper—it is delicate and recedes.

COLORS PC935 Black · PC1074 70% French Grey · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC932 Violet · PC949 Silver · PC914 Cream · PC928 Blush Pink

TRANSITION

Eye value transitions from dark iris-pupil center (PC935) → warm iris ring (PC1074 + PC1080) → cool iris ring (PC932) → cool grey sclera (PC949) → warm light glaze (PC914). Upper lid shadow cools as it recedes.

↔ If PC1074 is too grey, substitute PC1031 Henna (warmer iris). If PC949 is too cool, substitute PC1080 Beige Sienna (warmer sclera, though less accurate to cool reflection).

STOP WHEN

The iris reads round and luminous with at least three colors visible. The upper lash line is sharp, dark, and stands as the focal edge of the face. The sclera is cooler than the skin and never chalky white. · Hand is confident in the iris strokes; the lash line goes down in one intentional line.

> ✦ *The iris is a ball suspended in the socket, and light hits it from the same direction as the face. Keep it luminous by leaving the brightest arc on the lit side and keeping the pupil as a true void (deepest black). The eye is not a target; it is a sphere. A sphere always has a highlight, a midtone ring, and a shadow ring—show all three.*

05 Nose & Hand (Subsurface Scattering – Thin, Warm, Glowing)

Nose (tip, wings, bridge, septum), nostril shadows, the hand against the cheek (fingertips, nail, cast shadow)

Soft blending where the nose meets the cheek; very light pressure on the nostril shadows; the hand is a SEPARATE form in front of the face, not part of it — its edge stays crisper than anything behind it.

Light to Medium pressure

- Thin vascular areas — nose tip, nostril rims, and the fingertips pressed against the cheek — let light pass through, so they glow warmer and stay lighter even in shadow. This is subsurface scattering, not a highlight, and it is the most alive moment on the page.
- Nose tip and wings with PC928 Blush Pink at light-medium pressure, warmer and lighter than the surrounding cheek, so the nose sits almost in its own warm note.
- Nose base and bridge with PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure, keeping the warm light on the form; the nose reads most luminous at the tip where the skin is thinnest.
- Nostril shadows with PC935 Black at light pressure into the shadow at the nostril opening — soft edge, never a hard outline. The form reads from where the shadow sits, not from a line.
- Fine septum shadow (the line between the nostrils) with PC1031 Henna at delicate light pressure, fading in and out.
- THE HAND, not an ear — the ear is hidden in this reference. The fingers are a form IN FRONT of the face: glaze the fingertips and the pad against the cheek with PC928 Blush Pink at light pressure for the same translucent glow as the nose tip, then cool the backs of the fingers with PC1074 70% French Grey. A hand is cooler and greyer than a face, and that difference is what pushes it forward.
- The hand casts onto the cheek. Lay a soft PC1074 shadow under the finger edges and down the side of the hand, warming it with a touch of PC1031 Henna where it is closest to the skin — a cast shadow warms as it nears the surface casting it.
- The nail is the only hard, cool, non-skin note in this step: a pale cool wash, its edge crisper than any edge on the face, with one small reserved highlight. It is small, so it buys a lot of focus — do not let it compete with the eyes.

COLORS PC928 Blush Pink · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC935 Black · PC1031 Henna · PC1074 70% French Grey

TRANSITION

PC1080 Beige Sienna (nose base, warm light) → PC928 Blush Pink (nose tip and fingertips, the warmest glow) → PC935 Black (nostril shadow, soft edge) and PC1074 (backs of the fingers and the cast shadow). The face warms as it turns; the hand COOLS as it comes forward — opposite directions, which is what separates them.

Swap — if PC928 feels too saturated, substitute PC1001 Salmon Pink (lighter, less vivid glow). If the nostril shadows feel too dark, substitute PC1056 70% Warm Grey (softer dark). If you do not own PC1074, any mid cool grey carries the hand's role.

STOP WHEN

The nose tip reads warm and glowing, lighter than the face around it, and the nostril shadows are suggested rather than outlined. The hand reads cooler than the cheek and clearly in front of it, with its cast shadow soft underneath. · Hand stays light; the glow is never heavy, and the nail is the only place the pencil feels sharp.

✦ *The nose tip is the most translucent skin on the face — and the fingertips are its rival. Both should read noticeably warmer and lighter than what sits behind them. The trap in this pose is drawing the hand in the same colours as the face: then it melts into the cheek and the pose collapses. Keep the hand cooler, keep its edge crisper, and let the two warm glows — nose tip and fingertips — answer each other across the face.*

06 Lips & Mouth Structure (Upper Darker-Cool, Lower Lighter-Warm)

Upper lip, lower lip, lip line, mouth corners, teeth if visible

Glaze, glaze, glaze; burnish only in step 10. Soft edges everywhere; the crisp details (fine creases) go in step 10 with a sharp pencil and light pressure.

Light to Medium pressure

- The upper lip catches less light and stays cooler and darker. The lower lip catches light and is lighter, warmer, and more saturated. The lip line is soft, integrated, never a hard outline. Teeth are ONE lit mass with two or three suggested divisions, not outlined individually.
- Upper lip base with PC1017 Clay Rose at medium-light pressure, cooler and darker than the lower lip, sitting in the plane turn.
- Lower lip base with PC928 Blush Pink at light-medium pressure, the warmest local note on the face, lit from above and catching ambient light from below (bounce from garment).
- Lower lip lit edge with PC1031 Henna at light pressure, adding saturation and warmth to the transition from shadow under the lip to the lit upper surface; this edge is the most saturated note on the mouth.
- Lip line: soft integration with PC1031 Henna at very light pressure, subtle fine creases suggested only near the focal point (usually at the mouth corner); the line is never hard or outlined.
- Mouth corner shadow with PC1074 warm grey at soft edge, carrying the plane turn into the jaw; the mouth reads from temperature and value shift, not hard edges.
- Teeth (if visible) as ONE lit mass with two or three shadows suggested; paper white is the brightest note, and shadow around teeth defines their shape rather than outlining each tooth.

COLORS PC1017 Clay Rose · PC928 Blush Pink · PC1031 Henna · PC1074 70% French Grey

TRANSITION

PC1017 Clay Rose (upper lip cooler, darker) → PC928 Blush Pink (lower lip warm base) → PC1031 Henna (lower lip lit edge warmest). The lip line cools and darkens as it turns into the jaw with PC1074.

↔ If PC1017 is too cool, substitute PC1080 Beige Sienna (warmer upper lip). If PC1031 feels too red, substitute PC1084 Ginger Root (more muted, less saturated lower-lip edge).

STOP WHEN

The mouth reads as one warm form with the upper cooler than the lower. The lip line is soft and suggested, not outlined. Teeth (if any) read as a unified lit shape with

shadows around them defining form. · Hand stays relaxed; the mouth is not a focal accent and must not be overworked.

✦ *The mouth is never the most saturated note on the face. That honor belongs to the eye (lash line) or the subsurface glow of the nose. If your mouth is screaming, it is overworked. Glaze it in, keep the edges soft except at the very tip of the lower lip, and move on. A mouth drawn with hard outlines reads like a doll, not a person.*

07

Jaw, Chin & Shaded Plane (No Facial Hair; Warm Plane with Cool Shadow Undertone)

Jaw front plane, jaw side plane, chin, jaw underplane shadow

The jaw shadow is one plane with a crisp turning edge and soft outer boundary; the cool undertone is a glaze only, not a fill. No hard edges except at the bone (crisp inner edge of the core shadow).

Light to Medium (the cool glaze is very light; the core shadow is medium pressure at the edge, fading outward) pressure

- The jaw under a warm light reads as a warm midtone front plane and a darker, warmer shadow side plane. A cool undertone is a NOTE within the shadow, never the shadow's main temperature. Facial hair is absent per subject ground truth, so the jaw reads smooth and the shadow edge clean.
- Jaw front plane: continue the facial warmth with PC1080 Beige Sienna or PC1017 Clay Rose at light-medium pressure, as the extension of the cheek and forehead, lit and warm.
- Jaw turning edge (side of jaw, jaw line where it turns away) with PC1074 70% French Grey at medium pressure, building the warm shadow note; keep it visibly warmer than the face shadow to show the jaw is turning into a new plane.
- Cool undertone glaze along the shadow side of jaw (under the bone) with very light PC932 Violet at light pressure, a thin veil of cool that hints at the density of the tissue, not replacing the warmth but sitting within it.
- Jaw core shadow (beneath the jaw line, the underplane) with PC1056 70% Warm Grey at medium pressure, with a crisp inner edge where the jaw turns away and a soft outer edge into the neck; this edge is WARMER than a neutral grey and cools only as a NOTE.
- Chin shadowed side with PC1058 90% Warm Grey, deepening the shadow without making it ashy; keep it warm and keep the edge soft outward.

COLORS: PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1074 70% French Grey · PC932 Violet · PC1056 70% Warm Grey · PC1058 90% Warm Grey

TRANSITION

PC1080/PC1017 (jaw front warm) → PC1074 (jaw turning edge, warmer shadow) → PC932 cool accent glaze (thin veil of violet) + PC1056 (jaw core shadow, warm dark, not grey). The edge at the form turn is crisp; the outer edge into the neck is soft and warming.

↔ If PC1074 feels too grey, substitute PC1031 Henna (warmer jaw shadow). If PC1056 is not dark enough, substitute PC1058 90% Warm Grey (deeper). If PC932 is too purple, substitute PC1025 Periwinkle (softer cool undertone).

STOP WHEN

The jaw reads as a warm rounded form under warm light, with a crisp turning edge and a soft outer boundary. The cool undertone is barely visible, a hint only. The jaw

does not flatten or read as grey; it stays luminous and warm. No facial hair is visible; the jaw is smooth. · Hand is confident in the turning-edge line; it is one clean statement.

✦ *This step finalizes the jaw as a separate plane from the face, and it is where many drawings fail: a jaw shadow that is too cool, too dark, or too hard reads like a bruise or stubble, and a jaw that is not dark enough reads flat. Keep the shadow warm, keep the edge crisp only where the bone turns (inner edge) and soft where it melts into the neck (outer edge), and the jaw reads as a living form.*

08 Jaw, Chin & Where the Face Ends (No Neck in This Pose)

Jaw underplane resting on the hand, chin, contact shadow, cheek-to-hair boundary, pale sleeve bounce from below

No neck is visible — the face ends at the jaw and the jaw rests on the hand. Every value in this step belongs to a BOUNDARY: contact shadow, bounce from below, and one edge deliberately lost into the dark hair.

Light to Medium (bounce very light; contact shadow medium, fading fast) pressure

- There is no neck in this reference. The face ends at the jaw, and the jaw is resting on the hand — so this step is not about building a neck, it is about what the lower face SITS AGAINST. Treat it as three boundaries: the contact with the hand, the bounce from the pale sleeve below, and the dark hair on the right.
- Jaw underplane, where the chin and jaw meet the hand, with PC1058 90% Warm Grey at its deepest — but only at the touch point. A contact shadow is darkest exactly where two forms meet and lifts immediately as it moves away, so it never spreads into a general dark under the jaw.
- The bounce comes from BELOW, from the pale lavender-grey sleeve — not from the beanie. Glaze PC1083 Putty Beige very lightly climbing upward from the jaw edge, strongest nearest the sleeve, fading as it climbs the cheek.
- Bridge that grey bounce into the warmth of the face with PC1017 Clay Rose at light pressure, so the reflected grey integrates with the skin instead of sitting on top of it as a cool patch.
- Chin-to-hand contact line with PC1056 70% Warm Grey at a soft edge — cooler than the face shadow but still warm. It is a plane change, never an outline.
- Jaw front plane with PC914 Cream or PC1080 Beige Sienna at very light pressure, keeping the same light direction as the rest of the face so the lower face does not detach.
- On the right, the dark hair and the black collar are the opposite problem: that is where the jaw silhouette should be LOST. Let the edge dissolve into the dark mass rather than drawing a contour — this is the one silhouette edge the drawing owes the ground.
- The beanie's own bounce stays where it belongs — on the forehead and temple, above the brow. Light falls DOWN from a hat on the head; it does not travel up onto the jaw.

COLORS PC914 Cream · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC1083 Putty Beige · PC1017 Clay Rose · PC1056 70% Warm Grey · PC1058 90% Warm Grey

TRANSITION

PC1080 Beige Sienna (jaw front plane, warm light) → PC1017 Clay Rose (the bridge where the sleeve's grey bounce meets skin warmth) → PC1056 70% Warm Grey (contact line, cooler but still warm) → PC1058 90% Warm Grey (deepest, at the touch point only). The jaw cools as it turns under; the contact shadow warms again as it lifts off the hand.

Swap — if PC1083 reads too cool for the sleeve bounce, substitute PC1051 20% Warm Grey. If PC1058 is not deep enough at the contact point, substitute PC1099 Espresso (warmer dark) rather than reaching for black.

STOP WHEN

The jaw reads as resting ON something — a dark contact line that lifts away fast, not a general shadow. The sleeve bounce is a glow on the underjaw, not a colour block. On the right the jaw edge is lost into the hair rather than outlined. · Hand stays light; the contact point is the only mark that feels heavy.

✦ *With no neck to build, the temptation is to finish the jaw as a clean contour and stop. A head resting on a hand has no contour there at all — it has a contact shadow on one side and a lost edge on the other. If your jaw reads as a line, the face will look pasted over the hand instead of resting on it.*

09 Hair (Loose Strands), Hat & Background (Gestural Anchor, Fade & Surround)

Hair masses (scalp, hairline, loose strands per subject), hat (brim, crown, shadow), background (lighter behind shadow side, darker behind lit side)

Gestural, directional strokes for hair; anchor-and-fade for background. Never burnish the surround. Open tooth showing. Hair strokes follow the fall direction; background fades soft.

Medium (anchor) to Light (fade); all background is light pressure, very light as it fades pressure

- The surround is gestural, not rendered: anchor values at the face boundary, fade outward, and leave ONE silhouette edge lost into the background. Hair is never one flat value; it carries warm and cool notes. The hat reflects into the face and is its own grey-hue region. The background breathes by the rule: darker behind the lit side, lighter behind the shadow side, so the head reads in relief.
- Hair dark anchor at the scalp and hairline (where it meets the face) with PC935 Black or PC1076 90% French Grey at full strength, directional short strokes following the hair fall direction (from the crown down and over the shoulders per subject ground truth), then fade outward with PC1074 warm grey undertone woven through (hair is never pure black; it carries warm and cool undertones).
- Loose strands across the face and shoulder (per subject ground truth) with delicate, directional strokes of PC935 Black or PC1074 warm grey at light pressure, flicked at the silhouette and melting into the skin at the edges, not hard outlines.
- Hat in grey with PC1083 Putty Beige or PC1051 20% Warm Grey at medium pressure in the shadow side under the brim (if visible), then PC1059 10% Cool Grey or PC1052 30% Warm Grey on the lit side; anchor where it meets the hair (dark), fade soft upward and outward so the hat does not compete with the face.
- Background darker behind the lit side of the head (to push the light forward) with PC1076 90% French Grey or PC1074 at medium pressure, full strength near the silhouette, then fading outward.
- Background lighter behind the shadow side (to soften the shadow side and show reflected light) with PC1051 20% Warm Grey or PC1052 30% Warm Grey at light pressure, fading soft outward.
- Soft outer boundary of the background with no hard edge against the paper; the background melts into white by gradual fading, and ONE silhouette edge (usually the back of the head) is lost into the surround (not outlined).

COLORS: PC935 Black · PC1076 90% French Grey · PC1074 70% French Grey · PC1083 Putty Beige · PC1051 20% Warm Grey · PC1059 10% Cool Grey · PC1052 30% Warm Grey

TRANSITION

Hair dark anchor (PC935 + PC1076 + PC1074 warm undertone woven) → loose strands (light PC1074, melting into skin) → hat (PC1083 shadow side, PC1059/PC1052 lit side) → background (PC1076 dark behind lit side of head, PC1051/PC1052 light behind shadow side), all soft edges and soft outer boundary into white paper.

↔ If PC1076 is too dark for the background, substitute PC1074 70% French Grey (lighter, more saturated). If hair feels too flat, add PC1031 Henna warm undertone to the anchor. If the hat is too visible, reduce pressure and let it fade more.

STOP WHEN

Hair reads as an open gestural mass with texture and direction, not a rendered form. The hat is a quiet grey region that does not compete with the face. The background is darker on one side and lighter on the other, creating relief, and the outer edge is soft with NO hard line against white paper. · Hand stays loose; this is not a detailed pass, just anchoring and fading.

✦ *This is the fastest step and the most important for making the face READ. A background that is the same value all around makes the face sit flat on the page; a background darker behind the light side and lighter behind the shadow side makes the head jump forward. Leave this step GESTURAL—do not render the hat or hair like the face. The face is the finish; the surround is the frame.*

10 Edge Hierarchy, Burnish Face, Re-Punch Darks & Peak Highlights

Entire face and neck (not surround)

Burnishing with circular pressure until fusion, then hard re-punch, then edge softening with tools, then final glaze. This is a three-part move: fuse, restore, soften, unify.

Heavy (burnish), Medium-Heavy (re-punch), Very Light (final glaze) pressure

- Burnishing melts the layers of wax into a smooth, painted skin finish, but it lightens values and causes wax bloom (white flecks). Burnish the FACE ONLY with heavy pressure until the surface fuses, then wipe the bloom, and IMMEDIATELY re-punch the deepest darks, because they will have lifted. Then establish ONE focal edge (the upper lash line) as the hardest, sharpest edge on the entire head, and soften all other edges outward from it to create visual hierarchy. Finally, place the peak highlight—one bright spot—where the light is keenest.
- Burnish the face (forehead, cheeks, nose, mouth, jaw, neck) with PC938 White or a colourless blender at medium-heavy pressure using circular motions, until wax bloom clears and the surface fuses; the face becomes smooth and luminous, like painted skin, not pencil marks.
- Wipe wax bloom immediately with a soft cloth or chamois; this lifts the white haze and clarifies the colours beneath.
- Re-punch the deepest darks immediately after wiping bloom: upper lash line with PC935 Black at medium-heavy pressure (sharp edge, this is the focal accent and must be crisp and dark), nostril shadows, mouth corner shadows, eye pupils. These MUST re-enter because burnishing lifts them significantly.
- Peak highlight: the brightest spot on the face—usually the outer cheekbone or eye catch light—with PC1059 10% Cool Grey or paper white at a hard edge (one pencil stroke with a sharp point), creating the keenest light hit on the face. This is ONE small accent only, not multiple highlights.
- Soften all other edges outward from the focal accent using a tortillon or blender stump to break hard edges on the side of the face, jaw line, and temple; the outer edges of the face melt soft into the background.
- Warm final unifying glaze across the whole face (not neck or surround) with very light PC914 Cream or PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure, a single warm wash that pulls all the zones (golden forehead, red-pink cheeks, cool-violet jaw) into one moment under one warm light direction.

COLORS PC938 White · PC935 Black · PC1059 10% Cool Grey · PC914 Cream · PC1080 Beige Sienna

TRANSITION

The whole face reads as one warm-lit form after the final glaze; the sharpest edge (upper lash line) stands against the soft edges everywhere else, creating focal hierarchy.

↔ If burnishing lightens the face too much, the re-punch was incomplete; push the darks in harder. If the face feels too warm after the final glaze, reduce the amount of PC914/PC1080 or substitute a neutral glaze with PC1051 20% Warm Grey (much lighter touch).

STOP WHEN

The face is smooth, luminous, and reads like skin, not pencil marks. The upper lash line is visibly the sharpest, darkest edge on the head. The peak highlight is one small bright accent. All other edges are soft or lost. The face reads warm and unified under one light direction. The bloom is wiped and the darkest darks have re-entered. · Hand is confident in the burnish (circular, steady pressure); the re-punch and glaze are delicate touches.

✦ *Burnishing is the final technical move and the riskiest: it can fuse the colors into luminous skin or turn them to mud if you overwork it. The secret is speed and confidence—burnish, wipe, re-punch, and stop. Do not re-burnish or refinish; once it is smooth, it is done. The face is finished when you can see every value transition, every zone temperature, and the hierarchy of edges in one glance, and it reads as ONE person under ONE light, not a collection of colored pencil strokes.*

WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.